FREE TOOLKIT FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

Talking to Sceptical Stakeholders

Everyone carrying inclusion meets resistance. Here are the reframes, scripts and preparation to handle it constructively, from the boardroom to a one-to-one.

Practical toolkit About 10 minutes Updated October 2026

HOW TO USE THIS

1. Plan the conversation using the five preparation steps.
2. Find the objection you expect and read what it usually means.
3. Adapt one of the scripts in your own words.
4. Ask for one small, specific next step.

FILL IT IN ON SCREEN

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BEFORE YOU RESPOND TO THE OBJECTION, UNDERSTAND IT

Most resistance to inclusion work is not bad faith. It is often a combination of unfamiliarity, concern about unintended consequences, a different set of mental models about how organisations work, or previous experience of EDI activity that felt performative. Understanding which of these is driving the resistance will help you respond more effectively than having a pre-prepared rebuttal.

Before the conversation: five preparation steps

Plan your conversation as you read each step.

1 Know what they actually care about

Before the conversation, find out what this person is responsible for, what pressures they are under, and what success looks like in their role. Your argument will land better if it connects to what they are already trying to achieve.

What does this person care about, and what are they under pressure to deliver?

2 Bring evidence relevant to them

Generic data rarely moves people. Where possible, bring data about your own organisation, your sector, or your specific context. A business case framed in their language and linked to their priorities is more persuasive than external research.

Which evidence from your own organisation or sector will you bring?

3 Ask before you argue

Resistance is rarely just one thing. Before you deploy your arguments, ask questions: what specifically concerns you? What would it take to convince you? What would success look like to you? Listening first changes the dynamic and gives you better information.

What questions will you ask before you make your case?

4 Find common ground first

Almost all stakeholders share some version of: we want people to perform at their best, we want to retain our best people, we want to make good decisions. Start there. Build your case from the ground you share before moving to where you differ.

What do you already agree on?

5 Ask for something small and specific

The goal of a conversation with a sceptic is usually not full buy-in: it is the next step. Ask for something small and concrete rather than asking for commitment to the whole agenda. A small yes builds towards a bigger one.

What small, specific thing will you ask for?

Common objections and how to respond

Five objections you are likely to hear, what sits underneath them, and scripts to adapt.

OBJECTION 1 OF 5

This is divisive

"This is creating division, not resolving it."

What they often really mean

They often mean: this makes people uncomfortable, it highlights differences rather than common ground, and it feels like it is pulling the team apart rather than together.

The reframe

Inclusion work does not create division: it names divisions that already exist but have been invisible or ignored. When people from underrepresented groups share their experience and are believed, that feels uncomfortable to those who have not been aware of it. That discomfort is not division: it is awareness.

Conversation scripts

LEADERSHIP MEETING

"I understand this feels divisive, and I want to acknowledge that it can bring uncomfortable conversations into the open. But the evidence is consistent: when people are not able to bring their whole selves to work, or when bias operates unchecked in decisions, the divisions already exist. What we are doing is making them visible so we can address them. Research such as Deloitte's work on inclusive culture, and our own engagement data, point to inclusion as a driver of retention and performance, not a source of friction."

ONE-TO-ONE CONVERSATION

"I hear that this feels like it is creating tension. Can I ask what specifically feels divisive to you? Because often what I find is that the discomfort is coming from conversations that were not happening before, not from new divisions being created. I would rather understand what is driving that feeling for you so we can address it directly."

OBJECTION 2 OF 5

We hire on merit

"We already hire the best person: we do not need to change anything."

What they often really mean

They often mean: I believe our processes are fair, I do not think I have bias, and I am worried that EDI means appointing less qualified people.

The reframe

Merit is real and important. The question is whether our current processes reliably identify it. Decades of research show that identical CVs with different names receive different call-back rates, that interview panels consistently overestimate confidence as competence, and that referral-heavy recruitment reproduces existing networks. Improving our processes is not a compromise of merit: it is a better way of finding it.

Conversation scripts

BOARD OR LEADERSHIP LEVEL

"I want to be clear that what we are proposing is not about lowering the bar. It is about raising our confidence that our current bar is applied consistently. We know from audit research that identical qualifications produce different outcomes depending on the name on the application. Structured interviews, diverse panels, and blind shortlisting are not quotas: they are techniques for reducing the noise in our decision-making so that merit is what actually determines the outcome."

HIRING MANAGER

"You are absolutely right that we want the best person. What I want to ask is: are we confident that our current process is the best way of finding them? Do we know whether our interview questions assess what actually predicts performance in the role? Do we know whether our shortlisting is consistent? Because if we are missing great candidates because of how we have structured the process, that is a problem for performance, not just for EDI."

OBJECTION 3 OF 5

The data does not show a problem

"Our numbers look fine. Why is this a priority?"

What they often really mean

They often mean: I can not see a problem, so I am not convinced one exists. Or: the data I have been shown does not tell a compelling story.

The reframe

Diversity data is a starting point, not a complete picture. Representation at entry level can look healthy while progression rates and pay tell a very different story. And data about belonging and psychological safety is almost never collected, which means the most important dimension of inclusion is also the most invisible. The absence of evidence of a problem is not evidence of absence.

Conversation scripts

FINANCE OR OPERATIONS LEADER

"I want to look at the data more carefully with you, because I think there is more here than the headline numbers suggest. What I would like us to look at together is not just who is here, but who is progressing, who is leaving, and what our engagement scores show for different groups. In most organisations I work with, the first two numbers look fine and the second two tell a very different story. Can we set aside some time to go through the full picture?"

SCEPTICAL PEER

"The diversity figures are one part of the picture. What they do not tell us is whether people from different backgrounds feel equally able to contribute, raise concerns, or progress. We do not collect that data at the moment, which means we are navigating blind. I am not claiming we definitely have a problem: I am saying we do not yet know, and I think we should find out before we assume everything is fine."

OBJECTION 4 OF 5

We cannot afford it

"This is the wrong time. We need to focus on the business."

What they often really mean

They often mean: this is not a priority for me, the investment case is not clear, or I have genuine resource constraints that make this feel like a luxury.

The reframe

The cost of not investing in inclusion is real and ongoing: higher turnover, lower engagement, missed talent, reduced innovation, and increasing legal and reputational risk. The question is not whether we can afford to invest in inclusion, but whether we can afford not to. Many of the highest-impact interventions cost almost nothing.

Conversation scripts

CFO OR FINANCE DISCUSSION

"I want to make the business case as concrete as I can. Our current turnover in [area] costs us roughly [£x] per leaver when you factor in recruitment and lost productivity. Our engagement data suggests that employees who do not feel included are significantly more likely to leave within 18 months. If we can move those numbers by even a small margin, the ROI on inclusion investment is significant. I have built a model I would like to walk you through."

TIME-PRESSURED LEADER

"I hear that resource is tight. What I want to do is focus on the highest-impact, lowest-cost actions first so that we are not asking for a big investment before we have demonstrated value. The three things I would propose for the next quarter cost almost nothing in budget but will begin to shift our data. Can I show you what I have in mind?"

OBJECTION 5 OF 5

This is just box-ticking

"We are only doing this because we have to."

What they often really mean

They often mean: I am cynical about whether this will make a difference, I have seen EDI programmes come and go, or I think this is compliance theatre rather than genuine change.

The reframe

They are not wrong about the risk. A lot of EDI activity is box-ticking: training that does not change behaviour, surveys that get filed and forgotten, statements that do not translate into action. The answer to that cynicism is not to defend the activity: it is to commit to a different approach that is grounded in evidence, focused on outcomes, and honest about what is working.

Conversation scripts

CYNICAL SENIOR COLLEAGUE

"You are making a fair point, and I share the frustration with EDI activity that does not deliver change. That is exactly why I want to approach this differently. What I am proposing is not a programme of events and awareness days. It is a small number of commitments, with named owners and measurable outcomes, reviewed quarterly. If it is not working, we will say so and adjust. I would rather be honest about the challenge than defend activity that does not produce results."

RESISTIVE TEAM MEMBER

"I understand the scepticism: a lot of EDI work has been tokenistic and has not delivered real change. I want to be honest with you about that. What I am trying to do here is different, and I am happy to be held accountable for the outcomes, not just the activities. But I also want to understand your experience: what would it look like to you if this was working?"

YOUR CONVERSATION PLAN

Who I am speaking to

The objection I expect

My script, in my own words

The small, specific thing I will ask for

On navigating resistance

Resistance to inclusion work is not a sign that your work has failed. It is an expected feature of change work in any organisation where the status quo has benefited some people and disadvantaged others. The goal is not to eliminate resistance but to engage it productively.

The people who do this work most effectively are not those who never face pushback: they are those who have developed the skill of listening to objections, understanding what is underneath them, and responding in a way that opens dialogue rather than closes it.

Scripts with [square brackets] need your own figures. Use evidence you can stand behind and say where it comes from.

FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

You are not meant to carry this on your own.

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